



GM Wentzville Pilot: Coach Context Summary

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- Team leaders have about 40 to 50 seconds before the line stops.
- They cannot answer every call, so they have to triage.
- Operators working “in the hole” (behind in their station) pull the andon all day.
- Good triage depends on knowing each operator.
- The board’s tones and colors mean different things. A call is not always a line stop.
- Floor noise and constant bells compete for the team leader’s attention.
- Manpower shortages and competing issues pull team leaders elsewhere.
- “Letting it go” to keep the line moving leads to chasing a repair later.
- Team leaders get no data on their own response rate or effectiveness.
- Group leaders hold team leaders accountable unevenly.

Andon Response & Triage

- Response is a triage problem, not simply laziness. Team leaders (TLs) may expect operators to recover, be overwhelmed by competing issues, or be affected by noise, manpower shortages, and local culture.
- The andon system has important distinctions. An operator request does not necessarily mean the line has stopped. The board uses different tones and color-coded states for requests, line stops, blocked, starved, and normal operation.
- Responding to every call is unrealistic. Some operators trigger the andon repeatedly while working in the hole. Effective TLs must distinguish routine recoveries from issues requiring immediate intervention.

Environmental Pressures & Operations

- The environment is extremely demanding. TLs often juggle three to five important issues at once (sometimes more), including repairs, manpower, breaks, quality problems, and line stops.
- The floor is loud. Many operators tire of the bells and block out the manufacturing noise with one earbud or a speaker.
- Timing is critical to profitability. A typical production cycle is roughly 40 to 60 seconds; most run 52 to 56 seconds, with a range of about 49 to 67. Delays can turn a simple repair into downtime, rework, disassembly, or scrap. Estimated downtime at roughly \$10,000 per minute in variable profit loss.
- Quality depends on line stability. Repeated line stops disrupt operator cadence and create downstream quality problems.

Leadership & People

- The best TLs know their people and line. They understand individual personalities, work patterns, likely recovery behavior, and how to communicate with each operator. Experience and initiative matter.
- Accountability is inconsistent. Group leaders (GLs) do not always hold people accountable or treat them consistently, creating cultural problems.
- GLs and TLs have different perspectives. GLs monitor the broader operation and direct resources; TLs manage their section, operators, and local calls.

Data & Systems

- Data is fragmented. Downtime is tracked, but material, quality, and reason-code data are spread across systems. Leaders often lack access or time to correlate the information.
- TLs receive little performance feedback. Response rates, resolution rates, and effectiveness data would be valuable for coaching.
- GSIP matters. It is mainly a GL responsibility, and TLs are also expected to check and maintain it; in practice, a high percentage of TLs do not. On the IP line (the pilot line), there is one GSIP terminal, and TLs rarely have the capacity to proactively review open quality items while handling live andon calls. On other lines, TLs have GSIP open on their computer screens and monitor it more.

- Connecting plant data to the coach, and data-driven coaching, are future scope. They are not part of the pilot.

Implementation

- The prototype needs plant-specific language. These terms will make the coach more understandable and credible:
 - "line down"
 - "who pulled the andon"
 - "chasing a repair"
 - "in the hole"
 - "blocked" and "starved" (not "blockage" and "starvation")
 - "repeated line stops"
 - "manpower" (not "staffing")
 - "ship it" or "let it go": let the job continue down the line and fix the issue later ("We'll catch it later"). People say "let it go," not "let the andon go." Letting it go often leads to chasing a repair.
 - "variable profit loss": the plant's term for the cost of downtime. Plant leadership uses it often.
- The coach is a coaching tool. It does not track individuals, and it does not change standardized work or the andon procedure.